

Reflection on our Interview with Engr. Marvin Pintor

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Introduction

As part of our group's academic requirement to bridge classroom learning with real-world practice, we conducted an interview with Engr. Marvin Pintor, a Computer Engineering graduate. The purpose of our interview was to gain insights into his career path, the challenges he faced, the skills he uses daily, and to seek his guidance for our own futures as aspiring engineers.

Summary of the Interview

Engr. Marvin Pintor shared with our group that his start was not smooth after graduating as a Computer Engineer. He recounted searching for a job for almost three months before being accepted as an IT Support / Network Technician. In that role, he gained his first industry experience, setting up network infrastructure and troubleshooting hardware and software issues. After a few years, he shifted to software development, studying programming languages on his own while working. Through perseverance, he was promoted from Junior Developer to Software Engineer, and now holds the position of Senior Systems / Software Engineer.

He outlined his common tasks, which include creating and updating system features, fixing bugs and errors, reviewing other developers' code, assisting in system design, and documentation. The skills he uses most are programming (backend and sometimes frontend), problem-solving, networking fundamentals, database management (SQL), and communication skills for team collaboration.

Personal Reflection

Our group was particularly struck by the alumnus's honesty about his non-linear career path. It was reassuring for us to hear that a successful professional did not have an immediate "smooth start" and that it's acceptable, even normal, to begin in a role that isn't your ultimate goal. His journey from IT Support to Senior Engineer demonstrated to our group that a career is a marathon of continuous learning, not a sprint straight out of college.

His answers about the most useful topics from his CPE studies had a significant impact on our group's perspective. We often wonder which of our subjects will truly matter, and his clear list—programming fundamentals, data structures and algorithms, computer networks, database systems, and systems analysis and design—gave us a concrete roadmap. It validated our curriculum and motivated us to pay closer attention in these core classes, seeing them not as hurdles but as essential tools.

Furthermore, his biggest challenge deeply resonated with all of us. The "lack of actual experience and confidence" he described is a common fear we share as students. His practical method of overcoming it—through self-study on platforms like YouTube and Udemy, asking seniors for feedback, and sacrificing personal time to practice and build projects—provided our group with a clear and actionable strategy. It empowered us to realize that we can begin building our confidence and experience now, rather than waiting for a job to give it to us.

Connection to Course or Program

This interview directly connected the dots between our current Computer Engineering program and the professional world we are about to enter. The alumnus explicitly named several of our core subjects as the most useful, which reinforced the practical value of our often-theoretical coursework. It confirmed for our group that the effort we invest in learning about networks, databases, and algorithms is not for grades alone, but is the foundational knowledge we will rely on daily in our future careers as engineers.

Conclusion

Our interview with Engr. Marvin Pintor was an immensely valuable experience for our entire group. It provided us with a realistic, motivational, and practical perspective on building a career in the tech industry. His journey and advice have given us a stronger sense of direction and a clearer understanding of how to navigate our own paths. We are truly grateful for his generosity in sharing his time and experiences with us.

Appendices

1. Pagka-graduate ko bilang Computer Engineer, hindi agad smooth ang naging start. Naghanap ako ng trabaho ng halos tatlong buwan bago ako natanggap bilang IT Support / Network Technician sa isang local company. Doon ako unang nagkaroon ng industry experience — pag-setup ng network infrastructure, troubleshooting hardware at software issues, at system maintenance. Ilang taon ang lumipas, nag-shift ako sa software development dahil nakita ko na doon talaga ako mas interesado. Nag-aral ako on my own ng mga programming languages habang nagtatrabaho. Unti-unti akong na-promote mula Junior Developer, naging Software Engineer, at ngayon ay nasa position na Senior Systems / Software Engineer, handling both development and system design.

2. Paggawa at pag-update ng system features o modules

Pag-fix ng bugs at system errors

Pagreview ng code ng ibang developers (code review)

Pagtulong sa system design o architectural planning

Documentation at reporting

Occasional meetings with clients o project managers

3. Skills na pinaka-nagagamit:

Programming (backend at minsan frontend)

Problem-solving at debugging

Networking fundamentals

Database management (SQL)

Time management at communication skills lalo na sa team collaboration



4. Sa lahat ng inaral sa CPE, ano ang pinaka-naging useful sa actual work

Maraming topics ang useful, pero pinaka-nagbigay talaga ng malaking impact

Programming fundamentals

Data structures and algorithms

Computer networks

Database systems

Systems analysis and design

5. Pinakamalaking challenge noong nagsisimula sa career at paano na-overcome

Pinakamalaking challenge ko noong nagsisimula pa lang ay kakulangan ng actual experience at confidence. Totoo yung sinasabi — iba ang classroom sa real-world. May mga time na hindi ko alam ang gagawin or ganoon lang kahirap ang task.

Na-overcome ko yun sa pamamagitan ng:

Pag-aaral sa YouTube, Udemy, documentation,  StackOverflow

Pagtatanong sa seniors at paghingi ng feedback

5. Pinakamalaking challenge noong nagsisimula sa career at paano na-overcome

Pinakamalaking challenge ko noong nagsisimula pa lang ay kakulangan ng actual experience at confidence. Totoo yung sinasabi — iba ang classroom sa real-world. May mga time na hindi ko alam ang gagawin or ganoon lang kahirap ang task.

Na-overcome ko yun sa pamamagitan ng:

Pag-aaral sa YouTube, Udemy, documentation, StackOverflow

Pagtatanong sa seniors at paghingi ng feedback

Pagsasacrifice ng konting oras para mag-practice at mag-build ng personal projects

6. Number one na payo ko para sa isang current CPE student

Huwag mong hintayin ang industry para matuto — mag-invest ka sa sarili mong learning habang nasa college pa.



Transcript of the online chat interview conducted with Mr. Marvin Pintor

Note: The interview was conducted asynchronously via chat to accommodate the alumnus's busy schedule.